




**DEFINING CANVASES**
From left, 'The Disciple', 'Always Looking', 'The Third Eye'

dear friend and distinguished artist Bhupen Khakhar sits facing the viewer, while an image of a falling parrot in one corner harks back to 'Off Lamington Road', a painting made by his best friend and artist Gieve Patel, who was also a renowned poet, playwright and doctor. Another painting, 'Faletti's Hotel, Lahore', depicts artist Amrita Sher-Gil in Pakistan before the Partition. On the bottom, the words 'I hold all the Indias in my hand' are painted in German—an ode to German artist Anselm Keifer's series of paintings.

"I question myself at times, 'Am I a parasite because I depend upon someone's art?' But then I realise that when I take them from one context and bring it in my own work, the meaning and context change," he reflects. A master of visual language, Dodiya seeks inspiration from art, cinema, literature, poetry and popular culture, to weave them into works across painting, installation, sculpture, and his iconic shutter works. At his studio in Ghatkopar in Mumbai, large enough to hold an art exhibition if he so desired, he works simultaneously on multiple projects. "It is also a kind of laboratory, and a lot of things emerge from there. I also have a large collection of books and my own archive," he says.

Although his office staff and assistants are among the first to see his works—and he values their thoughts despite their distance from the art world—it is his wife, artist Anju Dodiya, who is his strongest critic. "I'm always nervous before showing her my work because she can be really blunt," he laughs. "We have a very fine tuning. We like similar filmmakers, poets, writers and painters. She has a keen insight into my work, based on sharp observation," he shares. Previously, his brother was his first viewer, and Dodiya misses him immensely since his passing two and a half years ago. "I would show him my work, and he would say, 'Fantastic!' That's what I wanted to hear," he recalls with a smile. As the artist moves between the quiet of his Ghatkopar studio and the public eye of the capital, it is clear that, for him, the canvas is never truly finished in isolation. ■

***—Deepali Dhingra***

*At Vadehra Art Gallery, New Delhi, till Mar. 10*


'Study After Santiniketan Triptych', 1989

***(With the Lightness of Being)*** **by the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art (KNMA) Saket, Delhi, in collaboration with the Tyeb Mehta Foundation and Saffronart Foundation.**

**With more than 120 works, the exhibition includes rare paintings, drawings, sculptures, film and archival materials spanning his six-decade career. "For me, it was important to understand Tyeb's practice beyond its existing narratives. He has been seen either as a formalist or as someone who spent a lifetime depicting violence and pain," says Roobina Karode, KNMA's artistic director and chief curator. For her, Mehta is a contrarian whose relevance lies in his ability to confront the human condition with grace.**

**ON DISPLAY ARE OVER 120 WORKS, INCLUDING RARE PAINTINGS, DRAWINGS, SCULPTURES, FILM AND ARCHIVAL MATERIALS**

**The exhibition doesn't attempt to critique him—it's an obvious celebration of the artist and the man whose memories were fraught with divisive political violence. But Minal Vazirani, president and co-founder of Saffronart, applauds his restraint. "It's his way of thinking, not merely a formal choice. He reduced his language until only what was essential remained, trusting structure and composition to carry meaning," she says, underlining a legacy that was built on singing what couldn't be voiced.** ■

***—Arshia***

*At KNMA Saket, New Delhi, till Jun. 30*